GAMES VILLAGES PLAY

The ongoing Chhattisgarhiya Olympics are a celebration of traditional Indian games

While growing up, Kuleshwar Nag indulged in every game there was on offer in his village of Shankarpur in the Kondagaon district of Chhattisgarh. He would often get yelled at by family elders for not attending to his studies, but it was hardly a deterrent. However, after the passing of his father, he was forced to quit school in the eighth grade; the play came to a halt as well.

It was a long wait for Nag to get back on the field. When the Chhattisgarhiya Olympics were announced last year, he knew he had to go. "I was always good at games, the leader of the pack. Through this event, I could once again captain the kho-kho and kabaddi teams and relive those childhood days," says Nag, 22.









STATE OF ACTION
Scenes from various games at the Chhattisgarhiya Olympics



The second edition of the Chhattisgarhiya Olympics was launched on July 17, an auspicious day when the state celebrated the festival of Hareli. It was started in 2022 to promote traditional games among youth, besides encouraging them to take up more conventional sports such as kabaddi, long jump, the 100m sprint and wrestling. The event gets underway in gram panchayats, where winners continue to compete at various levels at the zone, district and division, leading up to the final phase that will be held from September 25-27. "The Chhattisgarhiya Olympics not only allow people to socialise, but there's also a fitness element. The participation is huge and I was surprised to see even elderly women and men turning up," says Kartikeya Goyal, director, Panchayat Department, Government of Chhattisgarh. The event attracts around 3 million participants a year. Most are drawn to traditional games like *baati*, *gilli danda*, *fugdi* and *sankhli*, which they played in their childhood. Some of these are still popular in different neighbourhoods, but they now have a platform where anyone can step up and showcase their skills.

"I'm mostly engaged in agriculture, so this one day was a welcome change. The entire village watched me play. To hear my name on the loudspeaker after I won filled me with joy," says Rameshwari Sahu, 38, who hails from Newarikala. Age is no barrier either. Encouraged by his success last year, Kumbhlal Sahu, 78, from Khamaria village, stepped out yet again to participate in *baati*. "Normally, youngsters look up to us, but for once, I was inspired by the kids to step out. To play at the state level at my age was like a dream. Through the Chhattisgarhiya Olympics, there has also been a positive change in the people towards our culture, traditional garb and customs," says Sahu. ■

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